

Working Through the Labs

Ten labs, 405 minutes of hands-on work, one route through each.

Each lab in this manual is broken into timed phases so you always know roughly where you should be. There is a checkpoint at the end of each phase, a troubleshooting table for the problems that actually come up, and extension work if you finish ahead of the room.

How to use it

- Follow the phases if you want structure. Ignore them and work your own way if you would rather, the timings are a guide not a rule.
- The checkpoints matter more than the steps. If you can tick the checkpoint, you are fine however you got there.
- Extension tasks are genuinely optional. Nobody is expected to reach them.
- Prompts are written to be copied. Change the sheet and column names to match what you are working on.

Two things that solve most problems

- Your prompt is probably too short. Name the sheet, list the columns, say what you want, and say what shape you want it back in.
- On P2P_Raw and HR_Raw the real headers are on row 4, not row 1. Most formula errors on those sheets trace back to this.

Lab	What you build	Time	Module
1	A four-layer BLUF statement	35 min	01
2	A validated summary table	60 min	02
3	Three to five named metrics	45 min	02
4	A cleaned, prompt-ready dataset	45 min	02
5	Two charts with finding headlines	45 min	03
6	An AI dashboard prototype	40 min	03
7	A spoken two-minute story	35 min	03
8	Two rewritten prompts	45 min	04
9	A four-step prompt chain	20 min	04
10	A one-page decision brief	35 min	04

LAB 1

Find the story before you build anything

35 minutes

5 min	10 min	12 min	8 min
Choose	Explore	Write	Review

You are writing four sentences. No chart, no pivot table. The whole point is to prove you can find the story before you build anything.

PHASE 1 Choose your question 5 min

- 1 Open EL_DST_Training_Dataset_Full.xlsx and go to the Data Dictionary tab.
- 2 Scroll to section 3, the decision questions. Find the two or three written for your function.
- 3 Pick one. Do not spend longer than this choosing, any of them works.
If your function is not represented, take a Finance question. The framework is identical whatever the data.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You have one written question in front of you and you know which sheet answers it.

PHASE 2 Explore until something stands out 10 min

- 4 Open the sheet your question relates to. Click any cell in the data, then Data, then Filter.
- 5 Filter to the subset your question is about. High risk sites, or leavers only, or a single exception type.
- 6 Read the count in the status bar at the bottom right of the Excel window. Write that number down now.
If you cannot see a count, right-click the status bar and tick Count.
- 7 Now get a comparison. Change the filter to a different value in the same column and note that count too.
One number on its own is not a story. Two numbers next to each other usually are.
- 8 Ask yourself which of the two numbers would surprise your manager, and by how much.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You have at least two numbers written down.
- ☐ You can say which one is the interesting one and why.

PHASE 3 Write the four layers 12 min

Write them in this order. The headline comes last even though it is read first.

- 9 Evidence. Write three sentences, each containing one number from your exploring.
- 10 Context. Write one or two sentences explaining why those numbers matter, and to whom.
The test: name a person or team who would change what they do because of this.

- 11 Action. Write one sentence naming who does what, and by when.
"Investigate further" is not an action. "The AP team to audit the ten largest by Friday" is.
- 12 Headline. Now write one sentence containing your best number, that says what the reader should conclude.

If the headline will not come

Use this shape and fill in the blanks. It will not be elegant but it will be a real headline.

[Group] needs [action] because it accounts for [number] of [total].

PHASE 4 Peer review and sharpen 8 min

- 13 Swap with a partner. Read theirs aloud rather than silently, it exposes weak sentences fast.
- 14 Ask them only two questions: is there a number in the headline, and does the action name someone and a date.
- 15 Fix whatever they flag. Do not defend it, just rewrite it.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Your headline contains at least one specific number.
- ☐ Your action names a role and a deadline.
- ☐ Your partner could restate your recommendation after one read.

If this happens	Do this
I cannot find anything interesting	Filter to the extreme. The highest, the oldest, the worst performer. Interesting almost always lives at the edges.
My headline sounds obvious	Obvious to you is not obvious to a VP who has not opened the file. If it contains a real number, keep it.
I have too many findings	Pick the one you would act on first. The others become the evidence layer.

Finished early? Take it further

- Rewrite your headline for a different audience: once for your manager, once for a global partner who has never heard your team's acronyms.
- Find a second finding in the same sheet that contradicts or complicates the first. Real analysis usually has both.

LAB 2

Build a summary table with Copilot

60 minutes

10 min	15 min	15 min	12 min	8 min
Set up	First build	Validate	Extend	Finish

The longest lab in the programme. You are not learning Excel, you are learning to describe what you want and then check that you got it.

PHASE 1 Set up 10 min

- 1 Decide your function path: clinical, finance, HR or compliance. Stay in it for the rest of Day 1.
- 2 Open the matching sheet and make sure Copilot is available in the side panel.
- 3 Look at the column headers and read them out to yourself. You will need to name them in the prompt.
This sounds trivial. It is the single biggest cause of vague answers when people skip it.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Sheet open, Copilot open, and you can name every column without looking.

PHASE 2 First build 15 min

- 4 Copy the prompt for your path below into Copilot. Change nothing on the first run.

Clinical

I have a sheet called Site_Portfolio with columns Site ID, Study ID, Site Status, Risk Level and Open Site Queries. Create a summary table showing the count of sites grouped by Risk Level, filtered to Site Status equals Active. Return it as a table.

Finance

I have a P2P sheet with columns Invoice_ID, Vendor_ID, Amount, On_Time_Payment, Exception_Type and Cycle_Time_Days. Group by Exception_Type and show count, average Cycle_Time_Days, and the percentage of rows where On_Time_Payment is No. Return as a table sorted by count descending.

HR

I have an HR sheet with columns Employee_ID, Function, Region, Tenure_Months, Attrition_Flag and Engagement_Score. Show headcount, attrition rate as a percentage, average tenure and average engagement by Function, sorted by attrition descending.

Compliance

I have a Compliance sheet with columns Finding_ID, Owner_Function, Severity, Status, Days_Open and Repeat_Finding. Show finding count, percentage Critical, percentage Repeat and average Days_Open by Owner_Function.

- 5 Read what comes back before you apply anything. If it returned a formula, check the column letters actually match your sheet.
- 6 Apply it and look at the result. Does the shape make sense? Right number of rows, sensible totals?

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You have a summary table on screen and you understand what each column of it means.

PHASE 3 Validate 15 min

This is the phase people rush and it is the one that matters. You are proving the number, not trusting it.

- 7 Pick one cell in your summary and prove it yourself with a filter.
Example: Copilot says 49 Active sites are High risk. Filter Site_Portfolio to Site Status = Active and Risk Level = High, then read the status bar count. It should say 49.
- 8 Do it twice more on different cells. Three checks is the standard.
- 9 If a number does not match, do not fix the number. Work out which question you actually asked.
Usually the difference is a filter you meant to apply and did not mention in the prompt.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You have manually verified at least three values.
- ☐ Any mismatch has been explained, not just overwritten.

PHASE 4 Extend it 12 min

- 10 Add a second dimension to your table with a follow-up prompt.

Now break that same summary down by [second column] as well, so I can see whether the pattern holds across both.

- 11 Look at whether the pattern from your first table survives the split. Often it does not, and that is the interesting part.
- 12 Validate one cell of the new breakdown too.

PHASE 5 Finish and save 8 min

- 13 Write one sentence saying what your table shows. Not what it contains, what it shows.
"Counts by risk level" describes it. "Active high-risk sites are concentrated in two therapeutic areas" shows it.
- 14 Right-click the sheet tab, Move or Copy, tick Create a copy, rename it Summary and your name.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ A saved summary sheet with your name on it.
- ☐ Three validated values.
- ☐ One sentence stating the finding.

If this happens	Do this
Copilot gives a wrong formula	Reword the prompt, do not retype the formula. Add the column names again explicitly, that fixes it most of the time.
It keeps giving prose not a table	Add "return as a table with columns X, Y, Z" at the end.
My percentages exceed 100	Your denominator is wrong. Check whether you are dividing by the filtered subset or the whole sheet.
Copilot will not read my sheet	Paste ten sample rows directly into the chat and ask it to work from those instead.
I am behind on time	Skip phase 4 entirely. The extension is optional, the validation is not.

Finished early? Take it further

- Rebuild the same table in a second function's data and compare. Does the same shape of story appear?
- Ask Copilot to identify which single row of your summary it would lead with, then argue with it if you disagree.
- Add a calculated column that expresses one figure as a share of the total, so the table carries its own comparison.

LAB 3

Build your named metrics table

45 minutes

10 min	15 min	12 min	8 min
List	Test and cut	Name	Choose lead

You are turning correct numbers into useful ones. The cutting matters more than the listing.

PHASE 1 List everything you could measure 10 min

- 1 Open your Lab 2 summary. Everything here builds on it.
- 2 Write down every number you could calculate from it. Do not filter yet, aim for eight or more.
- 3 Include the obvious ones. Counts, averages, totals. You will cut most of them shortly.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ A list of at least six candidate numbers.

PHASE 2 Apply the test and cut 15 min

The test

If this number moved by ten percent, would my manager do anything differently?

Yes means keep it. No means cross it out. Be strict, the cutting is the exercise.

- 4 Go through your list one at a time and say the test out loud for each.
- 5 Cross out every no. If nothing got crossed out, you were not strict enough.
Raw counts almost always fail. "530 sites" does not change anyone's behaviour if it becomes 583.
- 6 You should be down to three to five. If you have more than five, cut again.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Between three and five metrics survive.
- ☐ At least two candidates were crossed out.

PHASE 3 Name them properly 12 min

- 7 Rewrite each surviving metric so the name says what it means, not which column it came from.
Not: Open_Site_Queries avg. Instead: Average unresolved queries per active site.
- 8 Check each one has a denominator, a comparison, or a concentration. If it has none of the three, it is still a raw count.

The four shapes that always work

- A share: X as a percentage of the total.

- A comparison: this group against the overall average.
- A concentration: how much of the problem sits in the worst one or two groups.
- A rate: events divided by opportunities, such as queries per site.

PHASE 4 Choose your lead 8 min

- 9 Pick the single metric you would lead a briefing with.
- 10 Write one sentence saying why that one and not another. You will be asked.
- 11 Mark it clearly. That number goes in your BLUF headline later today.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Three to five metrics, each named in business language.
- ☐ One marked as the lead, with a reason.

If this happens	Do this
Everything passes the test	You are being generous. Ask instead: which of these would I put in an email subject line? Only one or two survive that.
Nothing passes the test	You are working with raw counts. Add a denominator to each and try again.
I cannot choose a lead	Pick the one with the biggest gap between two groups. Gaps are what make people act.

Finished early? Take it further

- Take your lead metric and work out what it would take to move it by ten percent. That number is often more persuasive than the metric itself.
- Find a metric in a second function's data that would move in the same direction if yours got worse.

LAB 4

Clean a raw export and make it prompt-ready

45 minutes

5 min	10 min	15 min	8 min	7 min
Survey	Structure	Values	Verify	Prompt

Clean only the columns you actually need. That is the real-world habit, not a shortcut.

PHASE 1 Survey the damage 5 min

- 1 Open P2P_Raw or HR_Raw. Look at rows 1 to 3 before you touch anything.
- 2 Scroll the whole sheet once. Note what looks wrong without fixing it yet.

What you should be seeing

- P2P_Raw: 106 rows, 6 duplicates, 16 amounts stored as text, 14 vendor IDs prefixed V-, ten spellings of Yes and No.
- HR_Raw: 105 rows, 5 duplicates, 15 tenures written as text, 23 spellings of six function names, 12 spellings of three regions.

PHASE 2 Fix the structure 10 min

- 3 Select rows 1 to 3, right-click, Delete. Your headers move to row 1 where Excel expects them.
- 4 Select all data. Data, then Remove Duplicates. Tick only the ID column, untick everything else.
P2P_Raw should drop 106 to 100. HR_Raw should drop 105 to 100. If it drops further, you left too many columns ticked.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Headers on row 1, and exactly 100 data rows.

PHASE 3 Fix the values 15 min

- 5 Standardise the inconsistent text columns. Either Find and Replace (Ctrl+H) for each variant, or ask Copilot.

This column has inconsistent values. Standardise it so variants like 'procurement', 'PROCUREMENT' and 'Procurement ' all become one value, and tell me every variant you found.

- 6 Watch for trailing spaces. They are invisible and they break every grouping.
TRIM() removes them, or Find and Replace a single space at the end of the value.
- 7 Fix numbers stored as text. Look for \$9,096 or "15 months".
Find and Replace to strip the \$ the comma and the word months, then format the column as Number. Check it right-aligns afterwards, that is how you know Excel sees a number.

- 8 Decide what to do about blanks. Some are genuinely missing, some are meaningful.
In P2P, a blank Exception_Type means there was no exception. Do not fill those with anything.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Each category column has one spelling per value.
- ☐ Numeric columns right-align.
- ☐ You made a deliberate decision about blanks rather than deleting them.

PHASE 4 Verify against the clean tab 8 min

- 9 Build a quick summary of your cleaned sheet, then open the matching clean tab and build the same one.

- 10 Compare. They should match exactly.
Cleaned HR_Raw should give Procurement attrition 43.8 percent and company-wide 25.0 percent. If not, a category variant is still unmapped.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Your figures match the clean tab, or you know exactly which column does not and why.

PHASE 5 Summarise and prompt 7 min

- 11 Aggregate your cleaned data down to a small summary. Ten or fifteen rows, not a hundred.
- 12 Paste the summary into Copilot and ask one question about it.
- 13 Verify the answer against your own sheet before you accept it.

If this happens	Do this
My formulas return errors	The headers are still on row 4. Delete rows 1 to 3 first.
Remove Duplicates deleted too much	Undo, then run it again with only the ID column ticked.
Two values look identical but do not group	One has a trailing space or a double space. Use TRIM, or Find and Replace two spaces with one.
My numbers still will not sum	They are text. Select the column, look for the small green triangle, and use Convert to Number.
I am running out of time	Clean only the two or three columns your metric needs and move to phase 5.

Finished early? Take it further

- Write down the cleaning steps you used as a repeatable checklist. Next time this export lands, you will have a five-minute job instead of a forty-five minute one.
- Ask Copilot to write a set of Excel formulas that would do your whole cleaning routine automatically.

LAB 5

Two charts, two findings

45 minutes

8 min	14 min	11 min	7 min	5 min
Decide	Chart 1	Chart 2	Headlines	Silent test

One chart proves one claim. If you need two sentences to describe a chart, it should have been two charts.

PHASE 1 Decide your two claims first 8 min

- 1 Write down the two sentences you want to prove. In words, before you touch a chart.
- 2 Check each is a single claim. If a sentence contains "and", you probably have three charts not two.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Two written sentences, each making exactly one claim.

PHASE 2 Build the first chart 14 min

- 3 Sort your data before charting. Descending by value, unless it has a natural order like ageing buckets or months.
Never sort ageing buckets by size. You destroy the meaning of the sequence.
- 4 Select the data, Insert, Recommended Charts. A plain bar chart is almost always the right answer.
- 5 Strip it back. Delete gridlines. Delete the legend if there is only one series. Delete the axis title if the labels already say it.
- 6 Colour one bar to mark your finding, grey out the rest.
Click once on the bars to select all of them, then click again on just one to select only that one. Then change its fill.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ One chart, sorted, one highlight colour, nothing on it that does not serve the claim.

PHASE 3 Build the second chart 11 min

- 7 Same process for your second claim. It should take half as long now.
- 8 Use a different chart type only if the message needs it. Repeating a bar chart is fine.

PHASE 4 Write the headlines 7 min

- 9 Replace each chart title with your claim as a full sentence.
Not: Attrition by Function. Instead: Procurement attrition is 43.8 percent, nearly double the company average.
- 10 Read each headline and ask whether it tells the reader what to conclude. If it only says what the data is, rewrite it.

PHASE 5 The silent test 5 min

- 11 Show a partner both charts and say absolutely nothing.
- 12 They tell you what each chart says. If they get it wrong, the chart or the headline needs work, not your explanation.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Two charts, each with a finding as its headline.
- ☐ Your partner stated both findings correctly without you speaking.

If this happens	Do this
My chart has too many colours	Select all bars, click one bar again to select just it, colour that one and grey the rest.
I cannot fit the headline above the chart	Shorten it to the number and the direction. Detail belongs in what you say, not on the slide.
My partner misread it	Ask what they thought it said. The gap between that and your intent tells you exactly what to fix.
The chart mechanics are slowing me down	Ask Copilot to generate the chart. The learning objective here is the story, not the software.

Finished early? Take it further

- Rebuild one chart deliberately badly, with everything on it, then put them side by side. The contrast is a useful thing to keep.
- Try replacing one chart with a single large number and a sentence. Sometimes that communicates better than any visual.

LAB 6

Generate a dashboard prototype

40 minutes

8 min	10 min	14 min	8 min
Prepare	Generate	Refine	Compare

The refinement is the exercise. A first-attempt dashboard you accept unchanged teaches you nothing.

PHASE 1 Prepare the data 8 min

- 1 Copy your summary table. The small one, ten or fifteen rows, not the raw sheet.
Pasting hundreds of raw rows makes the output worse, not better. Summarise first.
- 2 Check the column headers are clear on their own. Rename anything cryptic before you paste.

PHASE 2 First generation 10 min

- 3 Paste into Claude or Copilot with this prompt.

Here is a summary table with columns [list your columns]. Create an interactive HTML dashboard with a sorted bar chart of [your metric] by [your dimension], and a small summary panel. Clean and professional. Put a finding sentence above the chart rather than a title.

- 4 Look at what comes back properly. Does each visual prove one claim? Is anything on it decorative?

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ A working dashboard on screen that you have actually read rather than admired.

PHASE 3 Refine at least twice 14 min

- 5 First refinement: fix the presentation.

Sort the bars descending, highlight only the top bar in colour and grey out the rest, and replace the title with a sentence stating the finding.

- 6 Second refinement: change something structural. Layout, what is emphasised, or what to remove.

Remove the summary panel and instead show the single most important number large at the top, with the chart underneath supporting it.

- 7 Compare version one against version three. Note what specifically improved.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You refined at least twice.
- ☐ You can name what changed between versions and why it is better.

PHASE 4 Compare and judge 8 min

- 8 Write down one thing the prototype does better than your Excel chart.
- 9 Write down one thing it does worse.
- 10 Answer this for yourself: when would you use this at work instead of Power BI, and when would you not?

The answer worth landing on

Artifacts for aligning with a stakeholder before anyone commits development time, and for one-off snapshots. Power BI for anything that refreshes, tracks change over time, or goes into a governed pack.

If this happens	Do this
The output looks generic	Your prompt did not say what the finding is. Tell it what the chart should prove, not just what to plot.
It will not render	Ask it to rebuild as a single self-contained HTML file with no external dependencies.
The numbers are wrong	Check what you pasted. If the summary was wrong, the dashboard faithfully reproduces the error.
I do not have Claude access	Use Copilot. The prompts work in both, the output may look different.

Finished early? Take it further

- Ask for the same data as three different dashboard layouts, then pick which one communicates best and say why.
- Add a second dataset from another function and ask it to show both side by side.

LAB 7

Deliver it out loud

35 minutes

7 min	6 min	10 min	6 min	6 min
Assemble	Rehearse alone	Round 1	Fix	Round 2

Reading a data story and speaking it are different skills. This is the rehearsal, so getting it wrong here is free.

PHASE 1 Assemble 7 min

- 1 Put your Lab 1 BLUF and your best Lab 5 chart side by side.
- 2 Update the BLUF if your numbers changed during Labs 2 to 5. They usually have.
- 3 Decide your one action sentence and write it out in full. You will deliver this from memory.

PHASE 2 Rehearse alone 6 min

- 4 Say it out loud once, against a clock. Aim for ninety seconds.
Out loud, not in your head. Reading silently takes about half the time speaking does and it will catch you out.
- 5 Cut whatever made you run over. Usually it is an explanation of how you calculated something.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ You have said it aloud at least once and you are near ninety seconds.

PHASE 3 Round one with a partner 10 min

- 6 Stand up if the room allows it. The capstone will be standing.
- 7 Deliver in this order and hold the pause.
Headline first. Then show the chart and stay silent for five full seconds. Then context. Then the action. Then stop.
- 8 Your partner responds with one thing only: the action they think you asked for. Nothing else.

About the pause

Five seconds feels roughly three times longer to you than to your listener. Count it silently rather than guessing. It is the most persuasive part of the whole delivery because it lets them reach your conclusion themselves.

PHASE 4 Fix what broke 6 min

- 9 If their action did not match yours, your layer four is the problem, not your delivery.
- 10 Rewrite the action sentence so it names a role and a date and nothing else.

PHASE 5 Round two 6 min

- 11 Deliver again, without looking at your written version this time.
- 12 Swap and listen to theirs. Give them the same one-sentence response.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Under two minutes, spoken not read.
- ☐ You held the five second pause.
- ☐ Your partner identified the action correctly.

If this happens	Do this
I keep running over	Cut the evidence to three data points and delete any sentence about method.
I cannot do it without reading	Deliver just the headline and action from memory, read the middle. Build from there.
The pause feels unbearable	It always does. Count to five silently. Nobody in the room finds it awkward except you.
My partner keeps mishearing the action	Say only the action sentence, alone, and ask what they heard. Fix that one sentence.

Finished early? Take it further

- Deliver it again for a different audience: once for your manager, once for a global partner. Notice that only the evidence layer changes.
- Cut it to forty-five seconds. It forces every remaining word to earn its place.

LAB 8

Rewrite two weak prompts

45 minutes

10 min	15 min	13 min	7 min
Find	Rewrite	Run	Conclude

Use real prompts from your own work. The comparison only teaches you something if you cared about the original answer.

PHASE 1 Find two real prompts 10 min

- 1 Open your Copilot or Claude history and find two prompts you actually used recently.
- 2 Pick ones where the answer was disappointing. Those teach the most.
- 3 Run both again as they are and save the output. You need the before.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Two original prompts and their outputs saved where you can compare them.

PHASE 2 Rewrite both 15 min

The three parts, every time

CONTEXT I have a sheet called [name] with columns [list them].

TASK Group by [X] and show [Y] and [Z].

FORMAT Return as a table sorted by [column] descending.

- 4 Rewrite the first prompt with all three parts present. Write it out fully rather than editing in place.
- 5 Check the task verb. Replace anything vague like "help me with" or "look at" with one precise verb.
Summarise, calculate, group, rank, flag, draft, rewrite. One of those, not a phrase.
- 6 Do the same for the second prompt.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Both rewrites name the data source and the columns.
- ☐ Both have one clear verb.
- ☐ Both say what shape the answer should come back in.

PHASE 3 Run and compare 13 min

- 7 Run both rewrites and put the outputs next to the originals.
- 8 Look for specific differences, not general impressions. Is it more accurate, better structured, more usable?
- 9 If the rewrite is not obviously better, add more context and run it once more.

- 10** Write one sentence identifying which of the three elements made the biggest difference.
For most people it is naming the columns. Context is the element people skip most.
- 11** Check the length. If your rewrite is about the same length as the original, you have not really rewritten it.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Two before-and-after pairs you could show someone.
- ☐ One sentence on what specifically changed.

If this happens	Do this
I cannot find real prompts	Use one from earlier today. Your Lab 2 prompt is a legitimate choice.
The rewrite is not better	Add a sample row of the data. That usually closes the gap immediately.
Both answers look the same	Your original was probably already decent. Pick a harder task and try again.

Finished early? Take it further

- Take your best rewrite and turn it into a template with square brackets, so you can reuse it next week on different data.
- Try the same rewritten prompt in both Copilot and Claude and note where the outputs differ.

LAB 9

Chain four prompts

20 minutes

3 min	12 min	5 min
Pick	Run the chain	Capture

The shortest lab. Run all four in one conversation, feeding each answer into the next question rather than starting fresh.

PHASE 1 Pick a question 3 min

- 1 Open the Data Dictionary tab and take one of the cross-domain questions.
- 2 Use Frontier or Co-work if you have access. Otherwise standard Copilot or Claude is fine.

PHASE 2 Run the chain 12 min

Step 1 · Get the shape

Summarise attrition rate by Function against the company average.

Step 2 · Narrow it down

Which function is furthest from the average, and by how much?

Step 3 · Test the connection

Does that same function also stand out in the Compliance sheet on repeat findings or average days open? Show both side by side.

Step 4 · Convert to a decision

Draft a two-sentence BLUF recommending where leadership should act first, naming an owner and a deadline.

Watch what happens between steps 2 and 3

Step two gives you a fact. Step three tests whether that fact connects to anything else. That transition is where a summary turns into something worth briefing, and it is the point of the whole lab.

PHASE 3 Capture it 5 min

- 3 Write down the BLUF from step four, and note what changed in your understanding between step two and step three.
- 4 Check the claim. If the AI stated causation, downgrade it to association.
"These two move together, and here is a plausible reason why" is honest. "X causes Y" is not supported by this data.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ All four steps run, not stopped at a summary.
- ☐ Your final output is a recommendation, not a description.

If step 3 comes back with nothing

That is a real answer, not a failure. Some things in this dataset genuinely do not connect. Saying so honestly is better than inventing a pattern, and your trainer will be pleased rather than disappointed.

Finished early? Take it further

- Run a fifth prompt asking what evidence would disprove your conclusion. It is the fastest way to find out how solid the story is.

LAB 10

Build the decision brief with AI

35 minutes

5 min	10 min	10 min	7 min	3 min
Choose	Chain	Validate	Assemble	Cut

This is your capstone draft

Whatever you produce here carries into Module 5. You get thirty minutes to refine it after this, not to rebuild it, so it is worth getting close now.

PHASE 1 Choose and commit 5 min

- 1 Pick one scenario: Operations, Finance, Cross-domain, or Full workflow. Do not try two.
- 2 Write the business question at the top of a blank page. Everything below serves that question.

PHASE 2 Chain your prompts 10 min

- 3 Run the four-step chain from Lab 9 on your chosen question.
- 4 Then ask for the brief itself.

I need to brief a VP in ninety seconds. Here are my numbers: [paste your summary]. Write a four-layer BLUF. Layer one is a headline containing a number. Layer two is why it matters. Layer three is three data points. Layer four is a recommendation naming an owner and a deadline.

PHASE 3 Validate every number 10 min

This is the phase that gets skipped under time pressure, and it is the one non-negotiable in the programme.

- 5 List every figure that appears in the draft.
- 6 Check each one against your source sheet. Filter, count, compare.
- 7 Delete or correct anything you cannot verify. Do not leave an unchecked number in.
If it is wrong in front of a leader, it is your name on it, not the tool's.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ Every number in the brief has been checked against source.

PHASE 4 Assemble one page 7 min

- 8 Put the BLUF and your best chart from Lab 5 on a single page.
- 9 Add nothing else. No appendix, no methodology note, no second chart.

PHASE 5 Read aloud and cut 3 min

- 10 Read the whole thing out loud once.
- 11 Cut any sentence that does not help someone decide. There is always at least one.

Checkpoint — are you on track?

- ☐ One page, one visual.
- ☐ Every number verified.
- ☐ Read aloud, and at least one sentence cut.

If this happens	Do this
The AI wrote something generic	It did not have enough numbers. Paste your actual summary table, not a description of it.
A number does not check out	Find out why before you change it. Usually the AI grouped differently than you assumed.
It will not fit on one page	Cut the evidence to three points and remove any sentence explaining method.
I am out of time	Prioritise validation over polish. An unpolished brief with correct numbers beats the reverse.

Finished early? Take it further

- Write the version you would send to a global partner instead of your VP. Keep the headline identical and change only the evidence depth.
- Ask AI to argue against your recommendation, then decide whether your brief survives the challenge.

Quick fixes across all labs

What is happening	What to do
Formula errors on a raw sheet	Headers are on row 4. Delete rows 1 to 3 first.
Copilot's answer is vague	You did not name the sheet or list the columns. Add both.
It wrote prose, you wanted a table	Add "return as a table with columns X, Y, Z".
Numbers do not match your check	Ask it to show its working. Usually the grouping or denominator differs.
Percentages exceed 100	Wrong denominator. Check whether you divided by the subset or the whole sheet.
Answer got worse with more data	Raw rows crowd out your question. Summarise first, then paste.
Two identical values will not group	Trailing space. Use TRIM or replace double spaces with single.
Numbers will not sum	They are text. Look for the green triangle and Convert to Number.
Chart has too many colours	Select all bars, click one again, colour that one and grey the rest.
Cannot get under two minutes	Cut evidence to three points and delete anything about method.
No idea what story to tell	Data Dictionary tab, section 3, decision questions for your domain.
Behind the room on time	Skip the extension work, never skip the validation.

Being stuck is not a problem. *Staying stuck quietly is. Put your hand up.*